Two K-Pop Stars Team Up for Their First Duo Album

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For more than ten years, Jeonghan and Joshua have shared the stage with their 11 bandmates in Seventeen, one of K-pop's best-selling groups. Now the two singers have their own project. "Dreamscape" is their first album as a **duo** called JxJ.

It is also Jeonghan's first new music since he finished South Korea's required **military service** this summer. While he was away, Seventeen kept performing, and he sometimes watched his bandmates from the audience with fans, who are known as Carats. "I missed those moments on stage," he told Variety.

Joshua spent that time **producing** songs and sending them to the group's company. Jeonghan said he was amazed by how clear an idea Joshua had about the album's musical direction. Joshua helped write his solo song, "Not Personal," and Jeonghan helped write the words to his solo, "Coloring."

At first, the two did not agree on their sound. Joshua said Jeonghan wanted a stronger style, while he wanted something **subtle** and mature. "Eventually, we met at the middle," Joshua said. The result is the title song "12 O'Clock," a dance-rock track inspired by disco and **funk** from the 1970s and 1980s. Its title refers to both noon and midnight, one time for chasing goals and one for dreaming.

The seven-song album mixes house, R&B, soul and band sounds. "We just really wanted the whole album to feel like a journey between traveling through dreams and reality," Joshua said.

Joshua grew up in Los Angeles. He said singing as a **duo** lets him show more of his voice, since his parts in the 13-member group can be very short. A tour is planned after the album's promotions.

Word Treasure

duo -- A duo is a pair of people who perform together.

military service -- Military service is time spent serving in a country's armed forces; in South Korea most men are required to do it.

producing -- Producing music means shaping how a song is made, from its sound to its recording.

subtle -- Subtle means gentle and not obvious or loud.

funk -- Funk is a style of music with a strong, bouncy rhythm and bass that makes people want to dance.

Background you need

K-pop is popular music from South Korea known for big groups, catchy songs and detailed dance routines.

Some K-pop groups form smaller units, so a few members can try a different style while still belonging to the main group.

South Korea requires most men to serve in the military, so K-pop stars often take a break from performing to do their service.

Seventeen is a 13-member group, and its fans are called Carats.

Break it down

LEAD: Seventeen's Jeonghan and Joshua release 'Dreamscape' as the duo JxJ
BACKGROUND: Jeonghan's first new music after military service; he watched the group from the audience
KEY DETAIL: Joshua produced songs while Jeonghan was away
+- SOLO SONGS: 'Not Personal' (Joshua) and 'Coloring' (Jeonghan)
+- COMPROMISE: strong vs. subtle led to the title song '12 O'Clock'
SOUND: seven songs mixing house, R&B, soul and band styles
PERSONAL: Joshua grew up in Los Angeles and gets to sing more in a duo
WHAT'S NEXT: a tour after promotions

Why it matters

The album shows how members of a big group can explore new styles and grow as artists in smaller projects. It also shows how two people with different ideas can compromise to make something new.

Test what you remember

1. What is the name of Jeonghan and Joshua's duo?

- (A) Carats
- (B) Dreamscape
- (C) JxJ
- (D) Seventeen

2. What did Jeonghan finish this summer?

- (A) A world tour
- (B) South Korea's required military service
- (C) A movie role
- (D) College

3. What are Seventeen's fans called?

- (A) Loser fans
- (B) Carats
- (C) Dreamers
- (D) JxJers

4. How did the two singers settle their disagreement about the album's sound?

- (A) Joshua gave up
- (B) They each made a separate album
- (C) They met in the middle between strong and subtle
- (D) They let the company decide

5. What music inspired the title song '12 O'Clock'?

- (A) Classical music from the 1700s
- (B) Heavy metal
- (C) Country music
- (D) Disco and funk from the 1970s and 1980s

6. How many songs are on the album?

- (A) Thirteen
- (B) Seven
- (C) Five
- (D) Twelve

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: B 3: B 4: C 5: D 6: B

Questions to think about

1. **Joshua: He wanted a subtle, mature sound and says the pair met in the middle on '12 O'Clock.'**

2. **Jeonghan: He wanted a stronger style and says he missed performing on stage during his military service.**

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):